

Fewer notices, or fewer illegalities?

A public claim, tested against twenty years of annual reports

THE CLAIM

“We had times when we issued over 1,000 enforcement notices per year.”

Johann Buttigieg, Planning Authority CEO, The Malta Independent, 7 September 2025

Now around 200, which he attributed to there being fewer illegalities.

The Authority's own 2024 report credits the fall to persuading contraveners first.

VERDICT

MISLEADING

*Accurate figures,
incomplete explanation.*

SUPPORTED

LARGELY
SUPPORTED

NOT
SUBSTANTIATED

MISLEADING

CONTRADICTED

MAIN RESULTS

1,033

Then: over 1,000 a year

Average notices a year 2001–2009 (MEPA). The figure is right.

187

Now: around 200

Average 2020–2024 (Planning Authority). Also right: notices fell 82%.

–11%

Complaints barely fell

2,701 complaints in 2009, 2,411 in 2024; 3,313 in 2020.

~1,200

Still confirmed illegal

About half of 2024 complaints were confirmed as illegal development.

521

Applications to legalise

In 2024 more cases ended in a sanctioning application than any other way; 162 got a notice.

FAIR TO SAY

The chief executive also said the Authority has struggled with enforcement. Persuading owners first is a recognised approach. This check is about what fewer notices can show.

WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT

☐ Complaints and outcomes for 2012–2018.

☐ Any survey showing illegal building has fallen.

☐ How many cases end in a sanctioning permit.

☐ The yearly source of 1,500 direct actions.